Chapter 3

Ancient Wisdom for Modern Challenges: Panchamahayajna

Introduction

The 21st chapter of the ninth Skandha of Sri Bhagavata Purana, describes the story of Rantideva [1]. Sri Shuka narrates about the lineage of Rantideva and eulogises him for his compassionate actions. He was a king who inherited a large amount of property from his ancestors. However he gave up all his wealth for the poor and needy and ended up extremely poor. Enduring hardships with his family, there came a time when they had nothing at all to eat. Many days passed and once he happened to get by chance ghee and some cooked rice (saṃyāva). He whose family was distressed and trembling due to utter starvation and parched with thirst, was about to partake the food when a Brahmana guest arrived, just at the time of their breaking the fast. Since

the king visualised 'Ishwara' everywhere and in everybody, he happily offered his share of food to the guest who partook of the meal and left contented. Distributing the remaining food among themselves, while they were able to eat, another stranger arrived. Without any reluctance, Rantideva offered him food. After he ate and departed, there was very little food left. Then came another stranger surrounded by a pack of hounds. This person requested, "Oh King! Please give me and my dogs something to eat, we are hungry". The king received them kindly and gave to him and the dogs respectfully whatever food that remained with him. They left content and now there was only some water left to drink. While he was about to drink it, a Chandala came up and requested, "Give water to me please". Hearing his pitiful request, the king was deeply moved with compassion and he spoke thus, "I do not seek the highest position or powers or even emancipation from samsara[1]; I would rather prefer to dwell in all beings and undergo sufferings for them, whereby they may be free from miseries". Expressing such nobility of heart, the king who was compassionate by nature and full of fortitude, gave that water to the Chandala, though he himself was on the point of death through thirst. To him, Brahma and other Devas appeared and blessed him and he remained devoid of any desires, with his mind eternally fixed on Vasudeva.

The story of Rantideva is often cited as an example of the virtues of charity, selflessness, and righteousness, and it continues to be celebrated in Bharat's tradition as an inspiring tale of devotion to Dharma. But, is this idea of self sacrificing for the benefit of another person, a very singular idea appearing only in Bhagavata Purana? Unsurprisingly, no! The entire Purana-Itihasa corpus

[1] The cycle of Samsara is seen as perpetuated by karma and desire/attachment. Liberation or emancipation from samsara (called moksha) is considered the ultimate spiritual goal in many Indian traditions. This liberation is viewed as freedom from the limitations and sufferings of worldly existence.

of literature is abundant with praiseworthy stories in parallel to the story of Rantideva. In Shanti parva of Mahabharata, Bhishma narrates the story of a pigeon who sacrificed itself for removing the hunger of a hunter [2]. In another context from Mahabharata, Sage Markandeya narrates to Yudhishtira about the story of King Shibi who cut flesh from his own thigh in order to protect a dove and feed a hawk [3].

The famous dictum, 'Atithidevo bhava', originates in the Shishyanushasanam of the Shikshavalli in the Taittiriyopanishad; 'Shishyanushasanam' means the Guru is authoritatively giving final instructions to his student who has completed his stipulated study, and is now about to begin the independent life of a householder. The entire verse from Taittiriyopanishad of Yajur Veda [4] is:

मातृदेवो भव | पितृदेवो भव | आचार्यदेवो भव | अतिथिदेवो भव।

mātṛdevo bhava. pitṛdevo bhava.
ācāryadevo bhava. atithidevo bhava.

Be one to whom Mother is as Deva, Be one to whom Father is as Deva, Be one to whom a Teacher is as Deva, Be one to whom a Guest is as Deva. Or simply put, consider and treat your Mother, Father, Teacher and Guest as manifestations of Divinity.

This idea of deep concern for everything and anything other than oneself is not just an appreciation of the universal value of 'compassion'. If we try tracing the origin of this 'selflessness' aspect underlying the Indian way of thinking, we can see it to be the reflection of another profound underlying idea - "Interconnectedness of everything". This, in fact, forms the foundation on which the entire schema of traditions, practices and beliefs systems are built.

Are We Connected?

Many social scientists are of the opinion that it is this view of 'Interconnectedness' that distinguishes the western and eastern way of looking at things. An American social psychologist, Richard Nisbett's research on culture and cognition has explored how cultural factors influence perception, reasoning, and decision-making. In his book, "The Geography of thought- How Asians and Westerners Think Differently… and Why", he quotes -

> The collective or interdependent nature of Asian society is consistent with Asians' broad, contextual view of the world and their belief that events are highly complex and determined by many factors. The individualistic or independent nature of Western society seems consistent with the Western focus on particular objects in isolation from their context and with Westerners' belief that they can know the rules governing objects and therefore can control the objects' behaviour. [5]

From Vedic times to modern times, this view of interconnectedness is emphasised through dictums, stories, customs and practices. The entrance hall of the parliament of India is engraved with a verse which appears in Maha Upanishad and Hitopadesha - "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" meaning "The World is one family" [6].

Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, popularly known as Amma, emphasises the importance of understanding this interconnectedness to lead a harmonious life.

> Everything in the universe is interconnected. The universe is a net held by each of us. When there is movement in one corner of a net held by four people, it reverberates everywhere. At times, people have told Amma about

experiencing a sense of imbalance similar to vertigo. This can be due to the disturbance of cells in the ears. The situation with nature has become like this these days. With each tree man chops down, he is making his own coffin. When we milk a cow, we should leave some milk for its calf. But today man milks until he gets the last drop. This harms the next generation. For this generation at least some fresh water remains. People make money and procreate, but imagine if there was no water left to drink! Along with making money and procreating, it is important to think of preserving Nature for the future generations.

Say a fire breaks out in a 10 story building and the person living on the first floor cries out, "Please help! Please come down and help! If we all try together, we can put out the fire!" But the people living on the top floor say, "It is not my floor; it is yours. It is not my problem but yours". But soon it will become their problem too. What is "his" problem now will become my problem in the future. It will come back to us. We should be aware of that.

This is how it is currently. One thinks it is someone else's problem – not mine. If an earthquake happens in one place, all the planes can be grounded for hours. So many businessmen can then be affected. No exports or imports, and so on. Like this, an earthquake in one place can affect the world. So many lives around the world. It is because of this that Amma always says that there is harmony in the universe. [7]

Will this understanding help solve problems?

This concept has important implications for our understanding of the world and our place in it, and it can help us to cultivate

a greater sense of compassion, empathy, and connection with all beings and entities.

On a global scale, we all have acknowledged various problems like poverty, climate change, equality and so on. From various small scale local clubs to highest bodies like the UN, people have resolved to address these challenges in different measures. It is true that within their scope of work, through events, activities and awareness programs, each of them have produced outcomes. But still, until one's attitude changes, all these measures to eradicate global problems shall remain superficial without touching the crux of the problem.

The Framework of Yajna

Yajna, a name that resonates from the vedic times, plays a very significant role in Indian culture and tradition. We find the reference of Yajna everywhere in Vedic and Post-Vedic literature. In the Bhumi Sukta of Atharva Veda, which is a collection of beautiful hymns describing our Mother Earth, it is said that Yajna is one of the principles that uphold and sustain the Earth [8].

However, there is a general notion today that 'Yajna' is a relic of the past. But once we understand the significance and the idea behind 'Yajna' we will be able to appreciate it and perform it even in the wake of this twenty-first century. Though a layman would relate Yajna to all different fire sacrifices that were performed during vedic times, Dhatupatha or the text that gives the etymology of the Sanskrit words ascribes three meanings to the root word 'Yaj' from which the word 'Yajna' is derived. 'Yaj Devapuja, Sangateekarana Daneshu'. The threefold meanings are Devapuja or worship of Devas, Sangateekarana or to bring together for a

collective effort and Daana means 'to offer'.

The Panchamahayajna Model

'Pancha' in Sanskrit means five and 'Maha' means great. This Yajna addresses five important relationships that, if kept harmonious, ensure happiness and prosperity at the personal and social levels. Sanatana Dharma instructs everyone to follow these five Yajnas every day.

The first is known as Brahma Yajna or Rishi Yajna. All of us are indebted to the ancient seers and sages for the treasure house of knowledge they have gifted us. Brahma Yajna is to understand the essence of ancient scriptures like the Vedas. Spending time with a spiritually illumined Mahatma and contemplating on his / her teachings is the best possible way to conduct this Yajna. However not everyone can meet and spend time with a Satguru. The next best option is to study the Itihasa-Purana corpus like Ramayana or Mahabharata or Bhagavata Purana, or Upanishads according to our temperament and contemplating on the teachings and applying the principles we imbibed into our own lives. Persistent efforts in this direction makes one stronger and wiser day by day, and such a person will be less afflicted by sorrows and pains of the world.

The second of the Panchamahayajna is Deva Yajna or 'Worshipping the Devas'. Deva Yajna is cultivating devotion in one's heart with a very strong understanding that all creation is a manifestation of Iswara. "Isavasyamidam Sarvam", says the Isavasya Upanishad [9]. Everything here is Iswara. Mantra Japa or repeated chanting of the mantra, contemplating and meditating on the Divine, doing Archana or chanting of divine names of God, Bhajans, are all different forms of Deva Yajna. Simply put, praying everyday and maintaining an inner connectivity to Divinity is Deva Yajna. Deva Yajna is also showing gratitude towards forces of nature.

Each element of Nature has a presiding deity like Surya Deva for Sun, Indra for rain, Varuna for ocean etc. Human beings' existence is dependent to a greater extent on these natural forces, and showing them gratitude is an acknowledgement of the interdependence.

Pitr Yajna is the conduct of reverential bonding with parents, grandparents, and ancestors, fostering family values for the unity and well being of the family. Rituals for the deceased, famous as 'Pitru Tarpana' is a common practice amongst Hindus and the details of the rituals can be found in many Smritis. The Shraddha ceremony has become a very important part of religious and social life, presently. Accordingly, immediately after a man has died, offerings are made to provide for him. Very interestingly, in the Itihasa Ramayana, we can see the Avatara Purusha, Sri Rama, doing obsequies or funeral rights for Jatayu, the vulture, Bali the monkey king and even for the enemy, whom he killed, Ravana. As per vedic culture, our self identity is not looked at only from an individual standpoint but it includes the family and cultural background as well. The individual is considered independent and yet an essential and integral part of a larger family unit where the well-being of one member lies in the well-being of all. A certain amount of voluntary sacrifice is needed to understand and accept this.

Serving humanity is the fourth Yajna known as Nru Yajna or Manushya Yajna. If we can sit patiently and think calmly, we can appreciate that each of our existence today, including health, wealth, education, position etc. is not the result of our efforts alone. It could possibly be the cumulative effort of millions. Once we realise and acknowledge that inter-connectedness, it would be quite natural for us to perform this Yajna as an obligation towards society. We can share our knowledge, resources, time and also pray for others. Merely accumulating wealth alone is

'not really living'. We should enkindle the spirit of sharing and caring for our fellow beings. There was a prevalent custom in Kerala, which existed till 50 years back. In traditional houses, before they shut down their gates at night, one of the family members would call loudly to check whether there was any person starving that night. If somebody responds, only after having served them food, would the house gates be locked at night. If you explore further back in time, you can see people adhering to practices like eating their meal only after having fed somebody else etc.

In Mahabharata, Ramayana and other ancient works, we find many discussions on the importance of supporting fellow beings. For instance, when Draupadi was married into the Pandava family, Kunti tells her how to divide food among themselves and Pandavas.

> "First take a portion and offer it to the Gods. Then give some alms to a Brahmana. Feed some to those who are needy, and give some to men who are around. Then, divide the rest into two parts. O fortunate one! Give half to Bhima, because that dark youth with a strong body is like a mad bull and is a warrior who always eats a lot. Then divide the other half into six, among the rest of them." [10]

One part of one's income was compulsorily required to be given in charity. In retrospect, how small have we reverse metamorphosed into our cocoon of self-importance.

The fifth and the last Yajna is Bhuta Yajna acknowledging one's connection with the flora and fauna. Living in conformity with Nature, showing compassion to plants and animals considering them as the manifestation of the same Iswara, is Bhuta Yajna. Sanatana Dharma is not an anthropocentric culture having humans as the central and most important

element of existence. 'The Earth does not belong to us but rather we belong to the Earth' is the beautiful perspective that thrived here. When we are in harmony with the natural laws which are consistent, unbiased and non-separate from Iswara, we remain in harmony with ourselves. Feeding animals and birds around us and watering and nourishing trees and plants are examples of conducting the Bhuta Yajna. There are many houses in India where they still practise this Yajna very devotedly. Once a day at least, people would feed crows or dogs or cats etc. which live around.

Human beings are deeply interconnected with the natural world around them, relying heavily on both animals and plants for their survival and wellbeing. We depend on animals for food, clothing, transportation, companionship, and even medical advancements. Countless industries and livelihoods are built around the use of animals. Similarly, plants provide us with the oxygen we breathe, the food we eat, the materials we use to build and clothe ourselves, as well as the medicines that sustain our health. Plants also play a crucial role in regulating the climate, preventing soil erosion, and maintaining the delicate balance of ecosystems. This intricate web of interdependence means that the wellbeing of humans is inextricably linked to the health and preservation of the animal and plant life around us. Recognizing and respecting this symbiotic relationship is essential for ensuring a sustainable future for our species and the planet as a whole.

Conclusion

Isn't the concept of Panchamahayajna a breathtakingly beautiful idea expressing and acknowledging the interconnectedness between everything that surrounds us? This deeper understanding of the oneness of all Creation, teaches humans to love Nature, and to develop a sense of reverence and devotion to all.

Amma's words echo through our hearts, reminding us that our entire life can become a sacred worship when we use our body to serve, our mind to empathise, and our intellect to share knowledge with others. If we observe Her daily routine, we will discover that she is the perfect embodiment of this profound wisdom.

The transformation we envision for a brighter future can only be achieved through our collective efforts. However, if we fail to shift our perspective on the world, the solutions we devise to tackle the problems will remain superficial, and the root causes will continue to simmer beneath the surface, waiting to resurface in unexpected ways. The ancient wisdom of Panchamahayajna invokes an individual's smart choice to live more harmoniously. These deep-seated challenges can be addressed to a greater extent, through a more profound understanding of the interconnectedness of all existence if more people subscribe to such a model.

Activity: Yajna in our daily Lives

As a student, can you suggest how one can practicalize the Panchamahayajnas in our daily lives?

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